

cover story PAKISTAN

REUTERS/ATHAR HUSSAIN



COLLATERAL DAMAGE: The site of a bomb attack in Karachi on January 14, which left six dead

“ELECTIONS MUST BE HELD ON TIME.” MOINUDDIN HAIDER FORMER INTERIOR MINISTER

against Sharif in his speeches and dubbed him as Zardari's B-team, suggesting snidely that he should change his name to Nawaz Bhutto Zardari Sharif. Sharif dismisses such talk as immature rant “from a politician who publicly stated that he was willing to elect Musharraf ten more times in uniform if it was needed”.

Musharraf's government had secretly hoped that by postponing the elections from January 8 to February 18, the sympathy wave for PPP would diminish. But apparently, that hasn't happened. Also, the acute shortage of wheat flour, with prices doubling, and frequent blackouts in the capital, have added to the discontent of the people. If the elections are held in a transparent and free manner, PPP is most likely to emerge as the single largest party in the 342-strong National Assembly. If Zardari's PPP and Nawaz's PML(N) garner sufficient seats between them to not only form a government but have a two-thirds majority—although that is still a far shot—it would mean cur-

ains for Musharraf. They could then not only move to impeach him, but also have all his orders to sack the higher judiciary revoked. Many political analysts are convinced that Musharraf would have the election rigged to ensure that the political dispensation is not as threatening. To ensure that outcome, the government could go all out to cause a split in PPP. Says Salim Bokhari, editor of Islamabad's *The News*: “Zardari's biggest challenge would be to keep his flock together and prevent PPP from fragmenting.”

Concerns are also being expressed that Musharraf may not hold elections at all though the President's spokesperson Lt-General (retired) Rashid Qureshi categorically denies any such plan. Despite what political pundits say, there are indications that better sense may prevail in the military establishment, which now sees transparent elections and the army's disengagement from civilian affairs as the only way out. Army Chief General Ashfaq Kiyani recently passed strict instruc-

tions to his generals to avoid meeting politicians. Many army men have been called back from civilian posts.

Opinion about whether Zardari has the mettle for the battle ahead, though, still remains divided. So who is Asif Zardari? He was born in 1956 to a landowner from Nawabshah and one-time PPP stalwart Hakim Ali Zardari, who left the party after developing differences with its chairman Zulfikar. The elder Zardari was always an “urban Sindhi”, eschewing his ancestral lands for the comfort of the metropolis of Karachi. He owned the city's Bambino Cinema. His son, too, grew up in Karachi, and was educated at St Patrick's High School, which is also the alma mater of Musharraf. In his early days, Zardari was known as a “party animal” and a bit of a “playboy”—a description he now rejects as being coined by his “detractors”. But many Karachiites recall the frequent parties he threw at his family home, which also contained